

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Later Wittgenstein - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper I, Section A | 32 diagnostics, 7 solved PYQs and 6 original Mains models

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Later Wittgenstein - Solved Practice Workbook

Standalone workbook. It reproduces the complete practice apparatus of the Later Wittgenstein learning package and can be worked without the teaching sessions. Syllabus, verbatim: *Later Wittgenstein : Meaning and Use; Language-games; Critique of Private Language* - UPSC Philosophy Paper I, Section A, item 8. **Evidence discipline:** FACT: doctrine on which the standard sources converge · ANALYSIS: analytical reconstruction for exam use · CAUTION: a live scholarly dispute. Model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys; UPSC publishes no descriptive model answer for Philosophy Paper I. **Terminology and citation rule:** the English concept leads and the German term follows immediately in parentheses - *language-game (Sprachspiel)*, *form of life (Lebensform)*, *family resemblance (Familienähnlichkeit)*, *criterion (Kriterium)*, *symptom (Symptom)*, *avowal (Äußerung)*, *surroundings (Umgebung)*, *the dawning of an aspect (das Aufleuchten eines Aspekts)*, *when language idles (wenn die Sprache feiert)*. Remarks are cited by **Section number**, stable across editions for Part I (Section 1-Section 693); the *Investigations* is **posthumous** (1953, edited by Anscombe and Rhees), the *Blue and Brown Books* were **dictated** 1933-35 and published 1958, *On Certainty* consists of notes of 1949-51 published 1969, and the duck-rabbit figure is **Jastrow's** (1899).

What this workbook contains

Component	Count
Original diagnostic MCQs - 24 core plus 8 remedial drills	32
Question-specific option explanations	128
Unique examiner traps	32
Directly owned verified PYQs solved in full, 2018-2025	7
Supporting routed parts that bear on this clause but are owned elsewhere	3
Original solved Mains models - two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks	6

How to use it

1. Attempt the twenty-four core MCQs without notes, then read every option explanation, including those for the options you rejected. The key sequence is **unpatterned** - each answer was fixed independently - so no cycle can be guessed, and option lengths are matched so that the answer cannot be spotted by shape.
2. Attempt the eight remedial drills only after the core set. Each targets a confusion that recurs in scripts every year, from the posthumous status of the *Investigations* to the boundary against logical positivism and the ownership fence around Topics 06, 07 and 11.
3. Write each PYQ under time before reading its solution, and check your script against the **demand-decoding table** rather than against the model answer's wording. ANALYSIS: Three of the seven owned parts are private-language parts asked in three different framings, so hold that argument as a **structure** and not as two illustrations.
4. Read the three supporting routed parts for their **boundary notes**: each names Wittgenstein and is owned by Topic 06, and each carries an explicit statement of what this clause may and may not contribute. ANALYSIS: **2021**, the only year in which this clause owns nothing, is one of them.
5. Finish with the six original Mains models, two at each mark value, to test the same doctrine at three different lengths.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 original MCQs - 24 core diagnostics and 8 remedial error-targeting drills

Answer placement: each correct option was fixed **independently**, so the key sequence is unpatterned rather than rotated, and no cycle such as ABCD can be used to guess. Options are matched for length, specificity, grammar and visible formatting so that the answer cannot be spotted by shape alone. Every question carries four question-specific option explanations and one unique examiner trap.

Coverage: the twenty-four core questions run across the whole printed clause - *Meaning and Use*; *Language-games*; *Critique of Private Language* - together with the status of the Augustinian picture, the Section 43 hedge, what "use" excludes, understanding as mastery of a technique, the ambiguity of ostension and the prepared place, samples and the standard metre, family resemblance and the thread, the builders and objects of comparison, Section 23's list and its closing clause, surface and depth grammar, agreement in judgments, the lion remark, the three parts of Section 201, Section 202's ban on private rule-following, Kripke's provenance, Section 243's target, the diary and its manometer variant, the beetle's exact conclusion, criteria against symptoms, and Section 580 with the behaviourism reply. The eight remedial drills attack the confusions that cost marks every year: the posthumous status of the *Investigations*, the 2009 renumbering and Jastrow's figure, colour exclusion as a pressure rather than a refutation, the boundary against logical positivism, dissolution against refutation in the treatment of solipsism, the solitary-speaker objection, the scope of "leaves everything as it is", and the ownership fence around Topics 06, 07, 11 and Paper II.

MCQ 1. The status of the Augustinian picture of language

In Section 1-4 of the *Investigations*, what verdict does Wittgenstein pass on the picture of language he draws from Augustine's *Confessions*?

- A. That it is straightforwardly false, since no word whatever acquires its meaning by being correlated with an object that speakers can indicate.
- B. That it fits one primitive language-game exactly, and is defective only as a claim about the essence of all language.
- C. That it is a correct account of how children learn language, though a poor account of how adults later come to use it.
- D. That it is unintelligible, because the notion of a word standing for an object cannot be given any coherent sense at all.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Wittgenstein grants that the picture works for "table" or "chair", and Section 2-4 construct a language for which it is exactly right.
- **B:** Correct: the builders' language of "block", "pillar", "slab" and "beam" is offered as a case the picture describes perfectly, which fixes its status as one game generalised into an essence.
- **C:** Incorrect: this makes the point developmental, whereas Section 28-32 attack the picture's adequacy at every stage, including adult ostensive teaching.
- **D:** Incorrect: unintelligibility is a verdict Wittgenstein reserves for sentences with no specified use, and naming plainly has a use in the games he describes.

Examiner trap 1: Writing "Wittgenstein refuted Augustine's theory of meaning" throws away the characteristic later move, which is to shrink an alleged essence into one case among many rather than to declare it false.

MCQ 2. What Section 43 actually states

Which one of the following reproduces the doctrinal content of Section 43 most accurately?

- A. The meaning of a word is its use in the language, a definition Wittgenstein offers as covering every occasion on which the word "meaning" is employed by any speaker.
- B. The meaning of a word is the object it stands for, except in those cases where no object can be found, which are handled by the notion of a language-game.
- C. The meaning of a word is fixed by the speaker's intention in using it, since intention is what selects one use of a word rather than another on a given occasion.
- D. For a large class of cases - though not for all - in which we employ the word "meaning", it can be defined thus: the meaning of a word is its use in the language.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it drops the scope limiter, and Section 40's separation of a name's bearer from its meaning shows the hedge is doctrine rather than politeness.
- **B:** Incorrect: this preserves the referential model as the default and demotes use to a residual category, reversing the order of Section 1-12.
- **C:** Incorrect: it reinstates a private mental determinant of meaning, which Section 258 goes on to dismantle at length.
- **D:** Correct: the remark is stated with its own limitation, and the limitation is what prevents "use" from becoming a second essence.

Examiner trap 2: Quoting the remark without "for a large class of cases - though not for all" is the commonest misquotation in this syllabus item, and it converts a careful observation into the slogan Wittgenstein spent Section 65-71 avoiding.

MCQ 3. What "use" does not mean

Consider the following glosses on Wittgenstein's term "use".

1. How frequently the word occurs in a population of speakers.
2. The norm-governed role the word has within a practice.
3. Whatever application the individual speaker finds convenient.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct as an account of Section 43's "use"?

- A. 2 only
- B. 1 and 2 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: use is a role with standards of correct and incorrect application, which is why a rare sentence is fully meaningful and a speaker can misuse a word.
- **B:** Incorrect: frequency is a statistical property of a population and has no bearing on whether a given application is correct.
- **C:** Incorrect: statement 3 makes the individual the sole judge, which is precisely the position Section 258 shows to be empty.
- **D:** Incorrect: it combines both errors, leaving "use" with neither normativity nor determinacy.

Examiner trap 3: Treating "use" as "usage" invites the objection that meaning is decided by majority behaviour, which recreates at population level the collapse of "right" into "seems right" that the private-language argument exploits.

MCQ 4. Understanding a word

On the account developed at Section 143-155 and stated at Section 199, in what does understanding a word consist?

- A. In a distinctive inner experience of comprehension that accompanies the word and is available to introspection whenever the word is grasped.
- B. In possessing a mental image of the object designated, which can then be compared with new cases in order to settle whether the word applies.
- C. In mastery of a technique, exhibited in going on correctly with the word in the appropriate circumstances of a shared practice.
- D. In having formulated to oneself a definition of the word in terms of necessary and sufficient conditions for its correct application.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Section 151-152 show the flash of comprehension can occur and be followed by failure, and that fluent understanding often involves no such episode at all.
- **B:** Incorrect: an image is another sign standing in need of application, so it postpones the question rather than answering it.
- **C:** Correct: Section 199 states that to understand a sentence is to understand a language, and to understand a language is to be master of a technique.
- **D:** Incorrect: Section 66-71 show that many concepts admit no such definition, yet are understood perfectly well by competent speakers.

Examiner trap 4: Identifying understanding with performance turns the account into behaviourism; the correct statement is that performance is the criterion, and criteria are defeasible in both directions.

MCQ 5. The ambiguity of ostensive definition

What does Wittgenstein establish at Section 28 by pointing at two nuts and saying "This is called 'two'"?

- A. That ostensive teaching never in fact succeeds, so children must acquire their first vocabulary by some entirely non-ostensive route.
- B. That the learner will always take the word to name the objects indicated rather than any of their properties, which is why naming feels basic.
- C. That the pointing is unnecessary, since the accompanying words already convey everything required for the learner to fix the term.
- D. That the gesture leaves the lesson undetermined, since "two" might be taken for a number, a colour, a shape, a material or a proper name.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Wittgenstein never denies that ostensive teaching works; he denies that the pointing is what makes it work.
- **B:** Incorrect: Section 28 lists exactly the range of readings the gesture permits, and the object-naming reading is only one of them.
- **C:** Incorrect: Section 29-30 show that adding "this number" merely borrows an understanding of "number" and restarts the same difficulty.
- **D:** Correct: the remark states that an ostensive definition can be variously interpreted in every case, which is the argument's premise.

Examiner trap 5: Reading Section 28 as scepticism about ostension inverts its purpose: it is an inventory of what ostension needs, not a denial that ostension teaches.

MCQ 6. The chess-king and the prepared place

At Section 31 Wittgenstein says that being shown a piece and told "This is the king" teaches the use of the piece only under a certain condition. What is that condition?

- A. That the learner already occupies the practice far enough to recognise that pieces have roles and that a word is being introduced for one of them.
- B. That the learner has already been given a complete verbal statement of the rules of chess, including every legal move available to each piece.
- C. That the learner already possesses the concept of a king, since otherwise the sentence conveys no information that he could put to any use.
- D. That the learner is able to reproduce the shape of the piece from memory, since recognition of the shape is what the ostensive definition supplies.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Section 31 requires that "the place is already prepared", and the preparation is entry into the practice - attending, imitating, being corrected - not possession of the concept taught.
- **B:** Incorrect: an explicit rulebook is neither necessary nor sufficient, and Section 68 and 84 note that games are not everywhere circumscribed by rules.
- **C:** Incorrect: requiring prior possession of the concept would make learning it impossible and turn the account viciously circular.
- **D:** Incorrect: Section 31 mentions the shape of the king as something already known to a chess-learner, not as what the definition delivers.

Examiner trap 6: Glossing "the place is already prepared" as "already has the concept" makes Wittgenstein's condition unsatisfiable; the preparation is practical and pre-conceptual, which is why Section 5-6 place training before explanation.

MCQ 7. The standard metre

Why does Section 50 say that of the standard metre in Paris one can say neither that it is one metre long nor that it is not?

- A. Because its length has been shown by later measurement to differ marginally from the metre as that unit is now internationally defined.
- B. Because the bar possesses an extraordinary metaphysical property that removes it from the ordinary range of things to which lengths are ascribed.
- C. Because no measurement of any object can be exact, so that every ascription of length is strictly speaking neither true nor false of that object.
- D. Because that is its peculiar role in the language-game of measuring: the bar functions as the standard rather than as an object measured by it.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the remark is grammatical rather than metrological, and it would hold whatever the bar's physical history.
- **B:** Incorrect: Section 50 explicitly says that this is not to ascribe any extraordinary property to it.
- **C:** Incorrect: general inexactness would affect every object equally and would not single out the standard at all.
- **D:** Correct: the bar belongs to the means of representation, which is also why Section 16 counts colour samples as part of the language rather than as its subject-matter.

Examiner trap 7: Missing Section 50 costs marks in the private-language answer, because a sample that carried its own instructions would let a remembered sensation serve as a private standard.

MCQ 8. What family resemblance denies

Which one of the following states most precisely what the family-resemblance considerations of Section 66-67 deny?

- A. That any two things called by the same general term ever share a feature, since the network consists only of resemblances of detail.
- B. That concepts can be taught by examples, since examples always underdetermine the boundary of the concept being conveyed.
- C. That a general term must be backed by a feature common to all its instances if speakers are to use it correctly and intelligibly.
- D. That sharply bounded concepts exist at all, since inspection shows every concept to possess a blurred and extensible edge.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: many games plainly share several features; the survey shows only that no feature runs through all of them.
- **B:** Incorrect: Section 69-71 treat teaching by examples as the normal and adequate method for such concepts.
- **C:** Correct: the target is the requirement expressed by "there *must* be something common", which Section 66 identifies as a demand carried to the facts.
- **D:** Incorrect: "triangle" and "prime number" retain strict definitions, and Wittgenstein nowhere denies this.

Examiner trap 8: Overstating the doctrine into "definitions are impossible" makes it self-defeating, since the claim would then apply to the definition of family resemblance itself.

MCQ 9. The thread, and the status of the boundary

Consider the following statements about Section 67-71.

1. The strength of a spun thread lies in one fibre running through its whole length.
2. We do not know the boundary of "game" because none has been drawn.
3. A boundary may be drawn for a special purpose without discovering a hidden one.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- A. 2 and 3 only
- B. 1 and 2 only
- C. 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Section 69 states that no boundary has been drawn and that one may be drawn for a special purpose, which is a decision rather than a discovery.
- **B:** Incorrect: statement 1 reverses Section 67, whose whole point is that the strength lies in the overlapping of many fibres.
- **C:** Incorrect: statement 2 is also correct, and omitting it loses the distinction between an undrawn boundary and a hidden one.
- **D:** Incorrect: it includes the inversion of the thread analogy, which is the very image Wittgenstein uses against the demand for a core.

Examiner trap 9: Saying that the boundary is unknown because it is hidden restores the essence-demand in epistemic clothing; Section 69's point is that nothing has been concealed, because nothing has been drawn.

MCQ 10. What the builders' language establishes

The language of Section 2, consisting only of "block", "pillar", "slab" and "beam", is introduced in order to show which one of the following?

- A. That the earliest human languages consisted of single-word commands, out of which sentential structure gradually developed over long periods of time.
- B. That a language can be complete for its purpose while consisting of trained responses to calls rather than of descriptions of anything.
- C. That every language, however complex, can in principle be translated without remainder into a vocabulary of four basic terms.
- D. That naming is the fundamental linguistic function, from which ordering, questioning and describing are all derived by extension.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Section 130-131 warn that the invented games are objects of comparison, not hypotheses about the origins of language.
- **B:** Correct: Wittgenstein instructs us to conceive it as a complete primitive language, and Section 19-20 show that "Slab!" functions as an order because of its place in the transaction.
- **C:** Incorrect: no reductive translation is proposed, and Section 23's list of countless kinds runs in the opposite direction.
- **D:** Incorrect: the example is designed to displace naming from that position by exhibiting a working language that does not describe.

Examiner trap 10: Narrating the builders without stating what they establish converts an argument into an anecdote, and the argument is that completeness for a purpose is all a language needs.

MCQ 11. Objects of comparison

According to Section 130-131, what is the methodological status of the simple language-games Wittgenstein invents?

- A. Idealised models which display, in simplified form, the structure that our own language possesses in a more complicated arrangement.
- B. Preliminary hypotheses about the earliest stages of language, to be confirmed or refuted by anthropological and historical evidence.
- C. Objects of comparison meant to throw light on our language by way of dissimilarities as much as by way of similarities to it.
- D. Thought-experiments intended to establish which features of language are necessary and which are merely contingent additions.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: treating them as simplified models reinstates the assumption that one structure underlies all language, which the games are designed to loosen.
- **B:** Incorrect: no empirical claim is made, and Section 130-131 explicitly disclaim the role of preliminary studies awaiting confirmation.
- **C:** Correct: the remark says the games are set up as objects of comparison illuminating by dissimilarity as well as by likeness.
- **D:** Incorrect: sorting the necessary from the contingent is precisely the essence-seeking project that family resemblance dismantles.

Examiner trap 11: Calling the invented games "models of language" is a quiet reintroduction of the *Tractatus* assumption, and an examiner alert to method will notice it immediately.

MCQ 12. Section 23 and its closing clause

Which one of the following best captures the argumentative function of the list at Section 23?

- A. To classify the sentence-kinds of natural language into an exhaustive taxonomy on which a systematic theory of meaning can be founded.
- B. To exhibit a deliberately disorderly multiplicity, which is not fixed once for all, and to conclude that speaking is part of an activity or form of life.
- C. To demonstrate that all the apparent varieties of sentence reduce, on a sufficiently careful analysis, to the three basic types of assertion, question and command.
- D. To show that describing is the central use of language, with joking, praying and cursing understood as parasitic deviations from it.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: a tidy taxonomy would suggest an underlying principle of division, which is exactly the suggestion the list's disorder is meant to defeat.
- **B:** Correct: Section 23 states that there are countless kinds, that the multiplicity is not fixed since new games arise and old ones are forgotten, and ends with the form-of-life clause.
- **C:** Incorrect: no such reduction is offered, and the list mixes reporting, translating, riddling and praying without ranking them.
- **D:** Incorrect: describing appears as one item among many, and that demotion is one of the list's principal effects.

Examiner trap 12: Reproducing the list without the closing clause loses the textual bridge to forms of life, which is the sentence the 2022 answer most needs to quote.

MCQ 13. Surface grammar, depth grammar and "It is 5 o'clock on the sun"

On Wittgenstein's diagnosis at Section 350-351 and Section 664, what exactly is wrong with the sentence "It is 5 o'clock on the sun"?

- A. It is false, since the sun's rotation makes the assignment of any particular clock time to its surface incorrect as a matter of fact.
- B. It is ungrammatical, since the phrase "on the sun" cannot be combined with a time-of-day expression in a well-formed English sentence.
- C. It is unverifiable, since no observation could ever be made that would establish which hour obtained at the surface of the sun at any given moment.
- D. It is impeccable on the surface and has no specified use, since our practice of telling the time is tied to a place and a position of the sun.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: falsity presupposes a determinate use, which is exactly what the diagnosis says has not been supplied.
- **B:** Incorrect: the sentence is grammatically flawless, and that impeccability is why the difficulty is philosophical rather than linguistic.
- **C:** Incorrect: unverifiability is the positivists' category, and importing it here confuses Topic 07's criterion with Topic 08's grammatical method.
- **D:** Correct: surface grammar survives the transfer while use does not, which is the model for the verdict later passed on the diarist's "S".

Examiner trap 13: Reaching for "meaningless because unverifiable" here shows that the boundary against logical positivism has not been understood, and it costs marks in any comparison question.

MCQ 14. Agreement in judgments

At Section 241-242 Wittgenstein answers the charge that human agreement decides what is true and false. What is the substance of his reply?

- A. That agreement decides truth only in mathematics and in logic, where conventions are stipulated, and not in empirical discourse, where the world decides.
- B. That agreement among competent speakers is indeed the criterion of truth, provided the speakers belong to the same linguistic community.
- C. That what is true or false is what human beings say, while what they agree in is the language they use - not agreement in opinions but in form of life.
- D. That the question is unanswerable, since any criterion offered would itself require agreement before it could be applied to a particular case.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: no such division is drawn, and Section 242's measuring example is taken from ordinary empirical practice.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is exactly the relativist reading Section 241 is constructed to refuse.
- **C:** Correct: the reply separates the level at which truth is settled from the level at which determinate assertion is made possible.
- **D:** Incorrect: Section 242 gives a definite answer through the measuring case rather than declining the question.

Examiner trap 14: The decisive detail is Section 242's asymmetry - wildly varying measurements would give us no measuring rather than inaccurate measuring - and an answer that omits it has asserted the reply without arguing it.

MCQ 15. The lion

What does the remark "If a lion could talk, we could not understand him" establish?

- A. That understanding requires enough shared activity and natural history for us to tell what a speaker is doing, so vocabulary alone is not sufficient.
- B. That different human cultures are mutually unintelligible, since each rests on a form of life closed to inspection from outside it.
- C. That animals cannot possess concepts, since concept-possession requires a public language of the kind only human beings have developed.
- D. That translation between any two languages is strictly impossible, and that the apparent success of translating rests upon shared subject-matter alone.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the remark states a condition of intelligibility, and the lion's life offers too little shared purchase for us to identify his moves.
- **B:** Incorrect: Wittgenstein repeatedly imagines alien practices and then describes them, which presupposes that anthropological understanding is possible.
- **C:** Incorrect: nothing in the remark concerns animal cognition, and its subject is our position as would-be interpreters.
- **D:** Incorrect: Section 23 lists translating from one language into another as an ordinary language-game among others.

Examiner trap 15: Using the lion as a proof of cultural incommensurability contradicts Wittgenstein's own practice of describing imagined tribes, and it is the standard route by which a form-of-life answer slides into relativism.

MCQ 16. The three parts of Section 201

Which one of the following correctly reports the structure of Section 201?

- A. It states a paradox about rules, concedes that the paradox is unanswerable, and recommends that we accept communal agreement in its place.
- B. It states a paradox, diagnoses it as a misunderstanding arising from giving one interpretation after another, and asserts a grasping that is not an interpretation.
- C. It states a paradox, resolves it by appealing to a further and more precisely formulated rule, and warns that arriving at such a formulation is often extremely difficult in practice.
- D. It states a paradox, attributes it to the vagueness of ordinary language, and recommends replacing ordinary rules with rules of a formal calculus.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is Kripke's reconstruction rather than the remark, and Section 201 itself uses the word "misunderstanding".
- **B:** Correct: the three parts are the paradox, the diagnosis of interpretation-substitution, and the assertion of a way of grasping exhibited in obeying and going against a rule.
- **C:** Incorrect: a further rule would need a further interpretation, so the regress is structural rather than a matter of imprecision.
- **D:** Incorrect: the later Wittgenstein rejects the demand that a calculus underlie ordinary use, and Section 130-131 treat constructed systems only as comparisons.

Examiner trap 16: Quoting only the paradox and stopping converts a reductio into scepticism, which is the single most damaging omission available in this session.

MCQ 17. Section 202 and private rule-following

What consequence does Section 202 draw from the claim that obeying a rule is a practice?

- A. That rules can be followed only where a community actually exists to enforce them, since enforcement is what constitutes the standard of correctness.
- B. That every rule must be capable of explicit formulation, since a practice without a formulation cannot be transmitted from one person to another.
- C. That rule-following is a species of habit, so that the distinction between obeying a rule and merely acting regularly is one of degree only.
- D. That a rule cannot be obeyed "privately", since otherwise thinking one was obeying a rule would be the same thing as obeying it.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the remark concerns the distinction between obeying and seeming to obey, not the presence of enforcers, and the community question is separately disputed.
- **B:** Incorrect: Section 5-6 and Section 31 make training rather than formulation the primary mode of transmission.
- **C:** Incorrect: reducing rule-following to habit removes the possibility of mistake, which is what distinguishes a practice from a regularity.
- **D:** Correct: Section 202 states the consequence in exactly these terms, and it is the premise imported into the diary argument at Section 258.

Examiner trap 17: Failing to cite Section 202 before Section 258 makes the private-language argument look like a fresh assertion, when it is the application of a result already established forty remarks earlier.

MCQ 18. Kripke's reading

Which one of the following describes the status of the interpretation offered in Kripke's *Wittgenstein on Rules and Private Language*?

- A. It is presented by Kripke as the argument as it struck him rather than as exegesis, and it is contested by anti-sceptical readers such as Baker, Hacker and McDowell.
- B. It is presented by Kripke as a straightforward exposition of Section 201, and it is accepted as such by the great majority of Wittgenstein's commentators.
- C. It is presented by Kripke as a criticism of Wittgenstein, arguing that the rule-following remarks fail to establish anything about meaning at all.
- D. It is presented by Kripke as a reconstruction of the *Tractatus*, showing that the sceptical problem about rules was already fully present in the much earlier work of 1921.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Kripke's own framing is why the scholarly shorthand "Kripkenstein" exists, and the anti-sceptical readings treat Section 201 as dissolving rather than conceding a paradox.
- **B:** Incorrect: the reading is influential but disputed, and Kripke himself declines the exegetical claim.
- **C:** Incorrect: Kripke takes the argument to succeed, and supplies a sceptical solution rather than a verdict of failure.
- **D:** Incorrect: the book concerns the *Investigations*, and the *Tractatus* is not its subject.

Examiner trap 18: Attributing the sceptical solution to Wittgenstein without qualification is the fastest way to lose the scholarship mark, and the correction costs only the four words "as it struck Kripke".

MCQ 19. The target of the private-language argument

Which one of the following is the language whose possibility Section 243 puts in question?

- A. A language of encrypted signs deliberately devised so that nobody outside a small group of initiates can decipher what has been written down in it by another.
- B. A language used only in soliloquy, spoken aloud or silently by a person who has no interlocutor and expects none.
- C. A language whose words refer to what can only be known to the speaker - his immediate private sensations - so that another cannot understand it.
- D. A language invented by a single person and never taught to anyone else, though it could in principle be taught if he chose to teach it.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: a code is a public language encrypted, decipherable in principle, and its signs already carry public meanings.
- **B:** Incorrect: Section 243 introduces monologuists precisely in order to set them aside, noting that a researcher could learn their language.
- **C:** Correct: this reproduces Section 243's own narrowing, on which the words could not be understood by another even in principle.
- **D:** Incorrect: teachability in principle is exactly what the target lacks, so this describes a merely unshared public language.

Examiner trap 19: Half the available marks in the 2020 and 2024 parts are lost in the first paragraph by candidates who attack a secret code, and the remedy is to reproduce Section 243's narrowing before anything else.

MCQ 20. What collapses in the diary argument

In Section 258, what exactly is it that the diarist fails to secure by concentrating his attention on a sensation and writing "S"?

- A. A guarantee that his memory will in fact preserve the association between the sign and the sensation over any considerable period of time.
- B. A criterion of correctness, so that no distinction arises between applying the sign correctly and merely seeming to himself to apply it correctly.
- C. An assurance that the sensation he attends to is genuinely recurring rather than being a series of numerically distinct but closely similar sensations.
- D. A method of communicating the content of his diary to anyone else who might wish to read it and learn what the sign records.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this makes the argument turn on the reliability of memory, whereas the claim is that there is nothing here for memory to be reliable about.
- **B:** Correct: Section 258 concludes that whatever is going to seem right is right, and that this only means we cannot talk about "right" here.
- **C:** Incorrect: the identity of the sensation is not the issue, and Section 270 shows the argument survives even where identification is set aside entirely.
- **D:** Incorrect: incommunicability is a feature of the case as stipulated, not the defect the argument uncovers.

Examiner trap 20: Presenting the diary argument as an argument from fallible memory invites the reply that public memory is fallible too, which the correct formulation never faces.

MCQ 21. The manometer variant

What does Section 270 add to the diary argument by imagining that writing "S" coincides with a rise in blood pressure detectable by a manometer?

- A. It concedes that private ostensive definition can succeed after all, provided the sensation is correlated with some observable bodily change.
- B. It shows that sensations are identical with bodily states, so that the appearance of an inner realm is dissolved by ordinary physiological investigation.
- C. It shows that once a public criterion supplies the sign with a use, the question whether the inner identification was correct becomes irrelevant.
- D. It shows that the diarist's memory can be tested after all, so that the criterion of correctness is supplied by his own repeated observations.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the private ostension does no work in the improved case, which is the opposite of a concession that it succeeds.
- **B:** Incorrect: no identity claim is made, and Section 304 explicitly refuses to reduce the sensation to anything.
- **C:** Correct: Wittgenstein notes that whether the diarist recognised the sensation rightly has ceased to matter, which completes the diagnosis constructively.
- **D:** Incorrect: the manometer, not the diarist's memory, is what supplies the independent check.

Examiner trap 21: Omitting Section 270 leaves the argument purely negative; including it shows that the account explains what a working sensation-word actually rests on.

MCQ 22. The beetle-in-a-box

What conclusion does Section 293 draw from the supposition that everyone has a box whose contents only he can see?

- A. That the contents of the boxes must in fact be identical, since otherwise the shared word "beetle" could not be used successfully at all.
- B. That sensations do not exist, since a box that might be empty is indistinguishable from a box whose contents are constantly changing.
- C. That each speaker means something different by "beetle", so that communication about sensations is systematically illusory.
- D. That on the object-and-designation model of sensation-grammar the object drops out of consideration as irrelevant to the shared word.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the example's force lies in showing that identity of contents is not required for the word to work.
- **B:** Incorrect: Section 304 insists the sensation is not a something, but not a nothing either, and Section 293 attacks a model rather than a phenomenon.
- **C:** Incorrect: the argument runs the other way, since the word functions perfectly well however the contents may vary.
- **D:** Correct: the conclusion is expressly conditional on construing the grammar of sensation-expression on the model of object and designation.

Examiner trap 22: Leading with the beetle rather than the diary reverses the argumentative order; the diary carries the argument, and the beetle removes a residual temptation about shared words.

MCQ 23. Criteria and symptoms

In the *Blue Book's* example of angina, which of the following pairings is correct?

- A. Both the bacillus and the inflamed throat are criteria, since either will settle the question whether the patient has the illness.
- B. The bacillus is the criterion, established by definition, and the inflamed throat is a symptom, established by experience.
- C. The inflamed throat is the criterion, since it is what we actually observe, and the bacillus is a symptom inferred from laboratory work.
- D. Both the bacillus and the inflamed throat are symptoms, since neither is conclusive and both may be absent in a genuine case.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: treating both as criteria erases the distinction between what fixes the concept and what experience has correlated with it.
- **B:** Correct: we defined angina as the illness produced by that bacillus, and discovered by investigation that inflammation usually accompanies it.
- **C:** Incorrect: observability is not what makes something a criterion; the grammatical role fixed by the definition is.
- **D:** Incorrect: criteria are indeed defeasible, but defeasibility does not convert a definitional ground into an inductive correlation.

Examiner trap 23: Using a psychological example first makes the distinction look invented to save a doctrine about the mind; the angina case shows it is a general grammatical distinction.

MCQ 24. Section 580 and the behaviourism charge

Consider the following statements about Section 580 and Section 304, 307-308.

1. Section 580 asserts that there are no inner processes, only outward behaviour.
2. Section 304 insists that the sensation is "not a something, but not a nothing either".
3. Section 307 concedes that if he speaks of a fiction, it is of a grammatical fiction.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- A. 1 and 3 only
- B. 1 and 2 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: statement 3 is accurate, but statement 1 attributes to Section 580 an eliminativism that Section 304 expressly rejects.
- **B:** Incorrect: statement 2 is accurate, but pairing it with statement 1 makes Wittgenstein deny and affirm the inner in consecutive remarks.
- **C:** Correct: Section 580 says the *concept* of an inner process requires outward criteria, while Section 304 and 307 protect the phenomenon and locate the fiction in grammar.
- **D:** Incorrect: it retains the eliminativist misreading that the other two remarks are designed to prevent.

Examiner trap 24: The word that blocks the behaviourist inference is "defeasible": a criterion grounds an ascription without entailing it, so a single case of successful pretence refutes an equivalence but not a grammatical dependence.

MCQ 25. Remedial drill - the provenance of the Investigations

Which one of the following statements about *Philosophical Investigations* is correct?

- A. It was composed between 1936 and 1949 and published posthumously in 1953, edited by G. E. M. Anscombe and Rush Rhees, with Anscombe as translator.
- B. It was published by Wittgenstein himself in 1953, two years before his death, in a German edition followed shortly afterwards by an English translation.
- C. It was assembled by Kripke from Wittgenstein's papers and published in 1953, which is why its arrangement of remarks is partly interpretive.
- D. It was published in 1921 in German and in 1922 in a bilingual edition, and its Part I consists of six hundred and ninety-three numbered remarks.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the book is posthumous, its arrangement is partly editorial, and Part I's numbering is stable across editions and translations.
- **B:** Incorrect: Wittgenstein died in 1951, and he published only one philosophical book and one article in his lifetime.
- **C:** Incorrect: Kripke's involvement with Wittgenstein is a book of interpretation published in 1982, not editorial work on the text.
- **D:** Incorrect: those dates belong to the *Tractatus*, though the remark about 693 numbered remarks is itself true of the *Investigations*.

Examiner trap 25: Writing "Wittgenstein published the *Investigations*" is a factual error visible in one sentence, and avoiding it costs nothing but the word "posthumously".

MCQ 26. Remedial drill - citing the duck-rabbit

Which one of the following gives the correct citation practice for the duck-rabbit discussion?

- A. Cite it as *Investigations* Section xi, since Part II uses roman numerals that are stable across all editions and translations of the work.
- B. Cite it as "Part II Section xi / *Philosophy of Psychology - A Fragment*", since the 2009 fourth edition renamed and renumbered that material.
- C. Cite it as *Investigations* Section 293, since the beetle-in-a-box and the duck-rabbit belong to the same continuous discussion of inner experience.
- D. Cite it as *On Certainty*, since aspect-seeing belongs with the hinge propositions among the notes Wittgenstein wrote in his final years.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the numbering of that material is precisely what the 2009 revision by Hacker and Schulte changed.
- **B:** Correct: giving both forms makes the reference safe whichever edition the reader holds.
- **C:** Incorrect: Section 293 belongs to Part I and concerns the beetle, which is a different argument in a different place.
- **D:** Incorrect: *On Certainty* consists of notes of 1949-51 published in 1969 and answers Moore rather than treating aspect-perception.

Examiner trap 26: The associated factual error is attributing the drawing to Wittgenstein: the figure is Jastrow's, published in 1899, and Wittgenstein reproduces it.

MCQ 27. Remedial drill - colour exclusion

What is the correct account of the colour-exclusion difficulty in relation to the *Tractatus*?

- A. It refuted the picture theory outright in 1929, which is why Wittgenstein abandoned the *Tractatus* and began work on a completely new system.
- B. It was raised by Ramsey against Wittgenstein, who never acknowledged it anywhere in print and continued to hold elementary propositions to be logically independent.
- C. It concerned the impossibility of naming simple objects, and was resolved in the *Investigations* by the doctrine of family resemblance.
- D. It pressured the independence of elementary propositions, was acknowledged in "Some Remarks on Logical Form" in 1929, and the repair attempted there failed.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: it strains one commitment rather than refuting a system, and the later work developed over two decades rather than in a single break.
- **B:** Incorrect: Wittgenstein acknowledged the difficulty publicly in the 1929 paper he wrote on returning to Cambridge.
- **C:** Incorrect: the missing simples are a separate difficulty, addressed at Section 47 by showing that "simple" is relative to a language-game.
- **D:** Correct: "this spot is red" and "this spot is green" cannot both be true, though neither looks further analysable, and Wittgenstein later disowned the paper's proposed repair.

Examiner trap 27: Calling colour exclusion a knock-down refutation converts a philosopher's long dissatisfaction into a single decisive move, and examiners in transition questions look for the word "pressure".

MCQ 28. Remedial drill - the boundary against logical positivism

Which one of the following correctly states the relation between the later Wittgenstein and logical positivism?

- A. He rejects one criterion of meaning as firmly as one essence, treats fact-stating as one use among many, and dissolves rather than rejects metaphysical puzzles.
- B. He accepts the verification principle as the criterion of cognitive significance while adding language-games as an account of how verification is actually carried out.
- C. He belongs to the Vienna Circle and contributed the private-language argument to its programme of eliminating metaphysical pseudo-statements from discourse.
- D. He agrees that metaphysical sentences are pseudo-statements, and differs from the Circle only in preferring ordinary language to a formalised notation.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: his objection to the *Tractatus* - one essence mistaken for many uses - applies with equal force to any single criterion of significance.
- **B:** Incorrect: adopting verification would install exactly the kind of general criterion Section 43's hedge and Section 66-67 are designed to exclude.
- **C:** Incorrect: Wittgenstein was never a member of the Circle, though he conversed with Schlick and Waismann between 1929 and 1932.
- **D:** Incorrect: rejection is a verdict on a sentence, whereas dissolution is a treatment of a puzzle, and the difference is not one of notation.

Examiner trap 28: Assimilating the later Wittgenstein to positivism is common because both oppose metaphysics; the discriminating sentence is that the Circle imposes a criterion while he denies that any single criterion is available.

MCQ 29. Remedial drill - the verdict on solipsism

Which one of the following states the later Wittgenstein's verdict on solipsism at its correct strength?

- A. Solipsism is refuted, since the publicity of language establishes by a valid inference that other minds exist and that the external world is real.
- B. Solipsism is confirmed in what it means but not in what it says, since the limits of my language are the limits of my world.
- C. Solipsism is left untouched, since grammatical investigation concerns the use of words and can have no bearing on a metaphysical thesis.
- D. Solipsism is self-undermining and therefore dissolved, since the concepts needed to state it cannot have determinate application on its own terms.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: no inference to other minds is offered, and the fatal error flagged in the directive decoder is exactly "language is public, therefore other minds exist".
- **B:** Incorrect: that is the *Tractatus* treatment at 5.62, which the later work replaces with a grammatical route.
- **C:** Incorrect: the grammatical investigation bears directly on the thesis, since the thesis is stated in words whose application it examines.
- **D:** Correct: either the solipsist's terms are fixed by present seeming, in which case Section 258 applies, or he has conceded the public-type practice he denies.

Examiner trap 29: The 2019 verb is "culminates", which asks for a development; a script that presents the later argument as the early one repeated has answered a question about repetition rather than about culmination.

MCQ 30. Remedial drill - the solitary speaker

What is the correct reply to the objection that a man alone from birth could invent words for his own sensations?

- A. That such a man could not survive to adulthood, so the case is empirically idle and no philosophical conclusion can be drawn from it.
- B. That he would in fact be using a public language, since the concepts of sensation he employed would have been acquired from other speakers.
- C. That the target is logical privacy rather than solitude, and a solitary speaker may still employ stable, repeatable, public-type criteria.
- D. That his words would be meaningful but unteachable, which shows that teachability is not after all a requirement on meaningful language.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the objection is a thought-experiment about the conditions of meaning, and empirical implausibility does not address it.
- **B:** Incorrect: the case stipulates that he acquired nothing from others, so this begs the question rather than answering it.
- **C:** Correct: what the argument excludes is a sign for which no criterion of correctness is available even in principle, not a speaker who happens to be alone.
- **D:** Incorrect: conceding meaningful but unteachable words would surrender the conclusion the argument is meant to establish.

Examiner trap 30: Whether an actual community is required, or only in-principle shareable standards, is genuinely disputed in the literature, and an answer that states the dispute rather than settling it by assertion reads as scholarship.

MCQ 31. Remedial drill - "Philosophy leaves everything as it is"

What is the correct scope of Section 124's statement that philosophy leaves everything as it is?

- A. It concerns the actual use of language, which philosophy may not interfere with or found; it does not commit Wittgenstein to social or political conservatism.
- B. It concerns human institutions generally, and commits Wittgenstein to the view that any criticism of established practices lies outside philosophy's proper competence.
- C. It concerns the results of the sciences, which philosophy may neither confirm nor overturn, and says nothing at all about the use of ordinary language.
- D. It concerns philosophical theories, which are to be left standing because no method exists for adjudicating between competing philosophical systems.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the remark's own first clause restricts it, saying that philosophy may in no way interfere with the actual use of language and cannot give it a foundation.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is the quietism charge stated as if it were the doctrine, and it ignores the restriction the remark itself supplies.
- **C:** Incorrect: the sciences are not the subject of Section 124, whose topic throughout is grammar and its description.
- **D:** Incorrect: Section 128 holds that philosophical theses would be undebatable, which is a stronger claim than leaving existing theories standing.

Examiner trap 31: The honest position quotes the restriction and then concedes that the range of what philosophy may attempt is nevertheless narrowed very severely - a cost Wittgenstein accepts rather than an objection he answers.

MCQ 32. Remedial drill - the ownership fence

Which one of the following correctly assigns material that neighbours this clause without belonging to it?

- A. Saying and showing belong to this clause, verification belongs to Topic 07, and Strawson's persons belong to Topic 11 alongside Quine's holism and ontological relativity.
- B. Saying and showing belong to Topic 06, verification to Topic 07, Quine's holism and Strawson's persons to Topic 11, and fideist uses of "form of life" to Paper II.
- C. Saying and showing belong to Topic 06, verification to this clause, hinge certainty to Topic 11, and Ryle's category-mistakes to Paper II.
- D. Saying and showing belong to Topic 07, verification to Topic 06, hinge certainty to this clause, and Austin's performatives to Topic 11.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: saying and showing are the *Tractatus* doctrine and are owned by Topic 06, appearing here only as the position being revised.
- **B:** Correct: this reproduces the fence, and it also explains why 2021 is empty for this clause while its Wittgenstein part, on "Whereof one cannot speak", belongs to Topic 06.
- **C:** Incorrect: verification is Topic 07's criterion, and hinge certainty belongs to *On Certainty* as bounded enrichment rather than to Topic 11.
- **D:** Incorrect: the assignments are transposed, and Austin is a broader ordinary-language owner rather than part of Quine and Strawson.

Examiner trap 32: Naming a neighbouring doctrine in one clause earns a boundary mark; expounding it spends the answer on another syllabus item, and in a ten-mark part that expenditure is usually fatal.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Practice status and source discipline - read once, applies to every solution below

Every model answer here is independent learner practice and is **never** an official UPSC key; UPSC publishes no descriptive model answers for Philosophy Paper I. Question wording is reproduced exactly as printed in the official papers, including the printed anomalies the repository ledger flags. The 2018, 2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024 and 2025 Paper I texts are held locally, and the English wording of every part below - including the three supporting parts owned by other topics - follows the repository's verified Western Philosophy PYQ ledger. Remarks are cited by **Section number**, which is stable across editions and translations of Part I; works are cited by author, title and both composition and publication dates wherever they differ, because almost every text in this clause is posthumous. Interpretive disputes - whether Kripke's sceptical solution is Wittgensteinian, whether an actual community is required for rule-following, and whether "meaning is use" is a theory or a reminder - are flagged as contested rather than settled.

Answer-length convention used throughout this package. UPSC Philosophy Paper I parts are written longer than General Studies answers. The working bands used here are **10 marks - about 150 to 220 words**, **15 marks - about 250 to 330 words**, and **20 marks - about 330 to 400 words**. Every solution below sits inside its declared band, and the demand decoding, the verdict heading and the "why this earns marks" notes are teaching apparatus that sit **outside** the timed word count.

Coverage. ANALYSIS: Corpus signal: this clause owns **7 of 112** Western Philosophy question-parts in the 2018-2025 corpus, with **2021 the only year without an owned part**. All seven are solved in full below, followed by **three supporting routed parts** that bear directly on this clause while being owned by Topic 06, and **six original solved Mains models**, two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks. The internal distribution is worth knowing before the exam: the **private-language critique** is tested in 2019, 2020 and 2024 - three of seven parts, in three different framings; the **transition from the early to the later philosophy** in 2023 and 2025; **family resemblance** in 2018; and **form of life** in 2022. A candidate who prepares meaning-as-use but not the private-language argument as an *argument* has

prepared under half the clause.

Solved PYQ 1 · 2018 · Q1(c) · 10 marks

Question: How does the notion of 'family resemblance' help Wittgenstein to uphold that 'Language is a game'? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"How does ... help ... to uphold ...? Discuss." - an argumentative service , not a definition
Core issue	Why calling language a game is a description rather than an evasion of the demand for an essence
Scope boundary	Ten marks: the challenge, the survey, the analogy, the service rendered, one qualification
Ideal thesis	Family resemblance removes the requirement of a common essence, and games are the paradigm of order without essence
Non-negotiables	Section 65's challenge; "Don't think, but look!"; the thread; what the doctrine does not claim

Independent model answer

Thesis. Family resemblance does not describe language; it removes the obstacle to describing it - the assumption that a general term must be backed by a feature common to all its instances.

The challenge. At Section 65 an interlocutor presses the objection Wittgenstein's own early work would have pressed: you speak of language-games and never say what the essence of language is.

The survey. Section 66 replies with an instruction - *"Don't say: 'There must be something common' ... but look and see."* Board-games, card-games, ball-games, Olympic games, ring-a-ring-a-roses and patience defeat amusement, competition, winning and losing, skill and luck in turn, leaving *"a complicated network of similarities overlapping and criss-crossing"*, named at Section 67.

The service rendered. The refusal to define "language" ceases to be a defect; "game" is itself the paradigm family-resemblance concept, so the analogy applies the very notion that dispensed with essences; and games possess rules, training, moves and standards **without** an essence - exactly the combination the *Tractatus* thought only a shared logical form could supply. Section 67's thread makes it vivid: strength lies in the overlapping of many fibres, not in one running the whole length.

Qualification. ANALYSIS: It does not claim that no concept admits definition, that no two games share a feature, or that anything may be called a game: practice selects the relevant similarities, so open texture is not arbitrariness.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the verb is "help ... to uphold". Every paragraph must say what work the notion does, not what it is.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 220 words: thesis one line; challenge one; survey three; service four; qualification two.

- **Structure:** the challenge -> the survey -> the name and the thread -> the service -> the limit.
- **Doctrine:** no essence required; games as norm-governed without essence.
- **Evidence:** Section 65, Section 66, Section 67; the thread; the six defeated candidate-features.
- **Distinction:** *not required against impossible.*
- **Criticism:** unlimited resemblance, answered by practice-selected relevance.

Solved PYQ 2 · 2019 · Q3(b) · 15 marks

Question: Show how Wittgenstein's critique of solipsism culminates in the critique of private language.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Show how ... culminates in ..." - a development , with a beginning, a change and an endpoint
Core issue	What the later route supplies that the early treatment could not
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the early treatment briefly, the change of route, the dilemma, the limits
Ideal thesis	The early book could only say the solipsist's meaning was unsayable; the later argument identifies what is missing - a criterion of correctness
Non-negotiables	5.62 stated correctly; dissolution not refutation; Section 258 and Section 202; no proof of other minds

Independent model answer

Thesis. The critique culminates in the private-language argument because the later work replaces a claim about the limits of what can be said with a diagnosis of what the solipsist's own vocabulary lacks.

The early treatment. The *Tractatus* already declined to call solipsism false. 5.6 states that the limits of my language mean the limits of my world; 5.62 that what the solipsist means is quite correct but *cannot be said*; 5.64 that solipsism strictly carried out coincides with pure realism, the self shrinking to an extensionless point. The mechanism is saying and showing.

The change of route. ANALYSIS: The later argument is not that treatment completed. It relocates the trouble from the *limit* of language to the *grammar* of the solipsist's words, and it replaces the saying/showing distinction with the distinction between a criterion and mere seeming.

The dilemma. Ask what fixes the application of "experience", "real" and "mine" in the solipsist's mouth. If they are fixed by his present impression, then by Section 258 whatever seems right is right, *"and that only means that here we can't talk about 'right'"* - no rule has been given, so nothing determinate has been asserted. If they are fixed by stable, repeatable techniques, he has helped himself to the public-type practice his thesis denies. Section 202 has already established that obeying a rule is a practice, and that thinking one obeys is not obeying.

Supporting collapse of the asymmetry. Section 246 adds that *"only I can know whether I am really in pain"* is false in one way, since others often do know, and nonsense in another, since I do not learn of my pain by observation.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: This is a **dissolution**, not a refutation: no proof of other minds is offered, and Section 303's remark that one should try, in a real case, to doubt another's pain concerns where doubt has application. The thesis is self-undermining because it consumes the vocabulary needed to state it.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "culminates" asks for a development. Say explicitly that the **route** changed, and the answer stops being a narration.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: thesis two lines; early three; change two; dilemma six; asymmetry three; verdict three.

- **Structure:** thesis -> early -> change of route -> dilemma -> supporting collapse -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** saying/showing; criterion of correctness; avowal.
- **Evidence:** 5.6, 5.62, 5.64; Section 202, 244, 246, 258, 303.
- **Distinction:** dissolution against refutation; logical privacy against solitude.
- **Criticism:** the result is exactly as strong as the private-language argument it depends on.

Solved PYQ 3 · 2020 · Q4(c) · 15 marks

Question: "But could we also imagine a language in which a person could write down or give vocal expression to his inner experiences-his feelings, moods and the rest-for his private use?" Critically discuss the answer offered by Wittgenstein to this question.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Critically discuss the answer offered" - reconstruct the answer, then assess it
Core issue	The quotation is Section 243 itself, so the answer must begin where the remark begins
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: the narrowing, the diary, the constructive variant, two objections, verdict
Ideal thesis	The answer is no, because private ostension establishes no criterion of correctness
Non-negotiables	Section 243's own narrowing; Section 258; Section 265; Section 270; the memory and Crusoe objections

Independent model answer

Thesis. Wittgenstein's answer is that we could not, and the reason is not that such a language would be unshareable but that its words would have no standard of correct application.

Where the remark begins. Section 243 first sets aside the case that is not at issue: human beings who speak only in monologue, whose language a researcher could learn. The question is then narrowed to words that *"refer to what can only be known to the person speaking; to his immediate private sensations"*. ANALYSIS: The target is **logical** privacy - not a code, not soliloquy, not undisclosed feeling.

The diary. Section 258 tests the proposal. The diarist associates "S" with a recurring sensation and gives himself *"a kind of ostensive definition"* by concentrating his attention. But the ceremony can only mean that it brings it about that he remembers the connection rightly - *"and here we have no criterion of correctness ... whatever is going to seem right to me is right. And that only means that here we can't talk about 'right'."* Since Section 202 has established that obeying a rule is a practice, and that thinking one obeys is not obeying, no rule has been created.

The constructive variant. Section 270 completes the diagnosis. Suppose writing "S" coincides with a rise in blood pressure registered by a manometer: the sign now has a genuine use - and whether the sensation was identified rightly has become irrelevant. Whatever work the sign does is done by the **public** criterion.

Two objections. ANALYSIS: *Memory*: public checking also uses memory. Reply: it uses memory **plus** something independent - a chart, a record, another speaker - whereas Section 265 compares the private check to buying several copies of the same newspaper. CAUTION: *Crusoe*: a solitary man could invent sensation-words. Reply: solitude is not logical privacy; whether an actual community is required remains disputed.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The answer is decisive against private ostension as a foundation and denies neither sensations nor solitary speakers; Section 304's *"not a something, but not a nothing either"* fixes its exact strength.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the quotation is the text. Beginning where Section 243 begins, with the monologuists set aside, secures the target-identification mark most scripts lose.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: thesis two lines; narrowing three; diary six; Section 270 three; objections four; verdict two.

- **Structure:** thesis -> Section 243's narrowing -> Section 258 -> Section 270 -> objections -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** private ostension; criterion of correctness; rule as practice.
- **Evidence:** Section 202, 243, 258, 265, 270, 304.
- **Distinction:** logical privacy against secrecy and against solitude.
- **Criticism:** the memory objection stated fairly, and the community question left open.

Solved PYQ 4 · 2022 · Q1(c) · 10 marks

Question: Establish the tenability of later Wittgenstein's notion of language as form of life. □ **Printed wording:** the official English line itself prints "**motion**"; it is retained here rather than silently changed to "notion".

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Establish the tenability" - a defended thesis , with the untenability test explicit
Core issue	Whether "form of life" makes agreement the criterion of truth
Scope boundary	Ten marks: the printed word, the two textual anchors, the Section 242 test, one concession
Ideal thesis	Tenable as the enabling background of determinate speech, untenable as a theory of truth
Non-negotiables	Reproduce "motion"; Section 19 and Section 23; Section 241's discrimination; Section 242's measuring asymmetry

Independent model answer

A note on the wording. The printed line reads "motion"; the notion is language as a form of life.

Thesis. The notion is tenable read as a claim about the **enabling background** of practice, and untenable read as the claim that agreement decides what is true.

The anchors. Section 19 states that *"to imagine a language means to imagine a form of life"*, and says it while asking whether the builders' "Slab!" is a word or a sentence - showing that a vocabulary cannot be specified apart from an activity. Section 23 closes its list with the clause that *"the speaking of language is part of an activity, or of a form of life"*.

The tenability test. Section 241 asks: does human agreement decide truth? The reply distinguishes levels - *"It is what human beings say that is true and false ... That is not agreement in opinions but in form of life."* Section 242 adds that communication requires agreement not only in definitions but in **judgments**: if measurement results varied wildly, we should have not *inaccurate* measuring but **no** measuring. ANALYSIS: Removing the background yields not error but the disappearance of the subject-matter - the asymmetry a relativist reading cannot use.

Concession. ANALYSIS: The phrase occurs a handful of times (Section 19, Section 23, Section 241, PPF), so large doctrines built on it are interpretation, and no adjudication theory is given.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: "establish the tenability" requires you to name what would make it untenable and show that it does not follow. Do that in the thesis line.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 220 words: wording note one line; thesis one; anchors three; test five; concession two.

- **Structure:** printed wording -> thesis -> anchors -> the Section 242 asymmetry -> concession.
- **Doctrine:** agreement in judgments, not opinions; language inseparable from activity.
- **Evidence:** Section 19, Section 23, Section 241, Section 242's measuring case.
- **Distinction:** the level at which truth is settled against the level that makes assertion possible.
- **Criticism:** sparse occurrence; no adjudication theory.

Solved PYQ 5 · 2023 · Q4(c) · 15 marks

Question: What were the main reasons that led Wittgenstein to shift from picture-theory of meaning to use-theory of meaning? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"What were the main reasons ...? Critically discuss." - enumerate, then assess
Core issue	Whether the shift is a change of theory or a change in the demand for a theory
Scope boundary	Fifteen marks: four or five reasons, the positive replacement, the verdict
Ideal thesis	The reasons are cumulative pressures on one assumption: that meaning has a single hidden essence
Non-negotiables	Colour exclusion as a pressure ; Section 43's hedge; the <i>Tractatus</i> did not disparage ordinary language

Independent model answer

Thesis. The reasons are not objections to a doctrine of picturing so much as cumulative pressures on the assumption underlying it - that something single and hidden explains how any expression means anything.

Reason one: the diversity of use. Section 23 lists ordering, describing, measuring, reporting, hypothesising, story-telling, play-acting, riddling, joking, translating, thanking, cursing, greeting and praying, and observes that new games arise and old ones are forgotten. No general propositional form covers this, and describing is exhibited as one item rather than the paradigm.

Reason two: the failure of ostension. Section 28 shows that an ostensive definition "*can be variously interpreted in every case*"; Section 29-30 that adding "*this number*" borrows the understanding it was to supply; Section 31 that it teaches only "*when the place is already prepared*". Naming therefore cannot be the foundation of meaning.

Reason three: colour exclusion. "This spot is red" and "this spot is green" cannot both be true, yet neither looks further analysable, which strains the *Tractatus*'s requirement that elementary propositions be independent. Wittgenstein acknowledged this in "Some Remarks on Logical Form" (1929). ANALYSIS: It is a **pressure**, not a knock-down refutation, and he later disowned the paper's proposed repair.

Reason four: the missing simples. Section 47 shows that "simple" and "composite" have no absolute sense: whether a chair is simple depends on what a language-game counts as a part. The terminus of analysis was therefore not unsatisfied but unstatable.

The replacement. Section 109 puts description in place of explanation, and Section 43 states the positive thesis with its own limitation - "*for a large class of cases - though not for all*".

Critical verdict. ANALYSIS: Two cautions. The shift is not from an artificial to an ordinary language, since the *Tractatus* held everyday propositions to be in perfect logical order. And Section 43's hedge exists to prevent "use" becoming a second essence; the residual difficulty, unresolved, is how established use is distinguished from innovation and from error.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: number the reasons. An examiner marking "main reasons" is counting, and four clearly separated pressures read as control.

Exam-length execution - 15 marks, about 250 to 330 words: thesis two lines; four reasons ten; replacement two; verdict four.

- **Structure:** thesis -> four reasons -> the replacement -> the verdict.
- **Doctrine:** one general propositional form abandoned; description replaces analysis.
- **Evidence:** Section 23, Section 28-31, Section 47, Section 109, Section 43; "Some Remarks on Logical Form" (1929).
- **Distinction:** pressure against refutation; essence-demand against theory.
- **Criticism:** the normativity of use, conceded rather than concealed.

Solved PYQ 6 · 2024 · Q1(d) · 10 marks

Question: Why does later Wittgenstein think that there cannot be a language that only one person can speak - a language that is essentially private? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Why does he think ...? Discuss." - a reason, stated as an argument
Core issue	What "essentially private" means, and what its impossibility follows from
Scope boundary	Ten marks: the target, the five-step core, the beetle in one sentence, one qualification
Ideal thesis	Private ostension provides no criterion of correctness, hence no rule, hence no meaning
Non-negotiables	Four non-targets named; Section 258; Section 202; the solitary-speaker qualification

Independent model answer

Thesis. A language is essentially private only if its words are given meaning by private ostensive definition of logically private sensations; such a definition creates no distinction between correct and seeming-correct use, so no rule and no meaning is created.

The target, stated exactly. ANALYSIS: Section 243 defines it: words referring to "*what can only be known to the person speaking; to his immediate private sensations*", so that another cannot understand it. Four things are **not** the target: a secret code; talking to oneself; undisclosed thoughts; solitude.

The argument. (1) A sign has meaning only if there is a rule for its use. (2) A rule requires a criterion of correct application independent of present seeming - Section 202: obeying a rule is a practice, and *thinking* one obeys is not obeying. (3) Private ostension supplies no such criterion, the only check being a further seeming of the same kind. (4) Hence "correct" and "seems correct" coincide, and Section 258 concludes that "*here we can't talk about 'right'*". (5) Hence no rule, no meaning, no such language.

The illustration. Section 293's beetle adds that a private item which might differ in every box, change constantly, or be absent cannot fix the grammar of a shared sensation-word.

Qualification. ANALYSIS: The argument denies neither sensations nor solitary speakers; Section 304 calls the sensation "*not a something, but not a nothing*".

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: the five steps must be numbered. A ten-mark private-language answer that retells the diary without the steps has offered an anecdote.

Exam-length execution - 10 marks, about 150 to 220 words: thesis two lines; target three; argument five; illustration one; qualification two.

- **Structure:** thesis -> target and non-targets -> five-step core -> beetle -> qualification.
- **Doctrine:** private ostensive definition; criterion of correctness.
- **Evidence:** Section 202, 243, 258, 293, 304.
- **Distinction:** logical privacy against secrecy, soliloquy and solitude.
- **Criticism:** the solitary speaker, handled by the public-type criterion.

Solved PYQ 7 · 2025 · Q3(a) · 20 marks

Question: "We should look not to an ideal language which derives its meaning from facts and has a precise 'logical structure but empirically, to the ways in which languages are actually used." Explain the transition from early views of Wittgenstein to his later views on language and meaning with reference to this statement. □ **Printed wording:** the unmatched opening quotation before **logical structure** is visible in the official English line and is retained.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Explain the transition ... with reference to this statement" - anchor every stage to the quotation
Core issue	What exactly is being left behind, and what "empirically" does and does not mean here
Scope boundary	Twenty marks: the early position, the pressures, the later account, the method, the verdict
Ideal thesis	The demand for one essence is withdrawn rather than answered differently; clarification survives
Non-negotiables	The printed anomaly retained; the <i>Tractatus</i> did not disparage ordinary language; Section 43's hedge; a ruling

Independent model answer

Thesis. The statement's contrast is accurate in its direction and misleading in one respect: what the later Wittgenstein abandons is not an artificial language in favour of a natural one, but the demand that some single hidden structure explain how any expression means anything.

What the early view actually held. The *Tractatus* - German 1921, bilingual 1922 - gives one general propositional form, sense through the **depiction** of a possible state of affairs, and a shared **logical form** that cannot be said but shows itself. ANALYSIS: Crucially, it does **not** disparage ordinary language: 4.002 and 5.5563 hold everyday propositions to be, just as they stand, in perfect logical order. The "ideal language" of the quoted statement is therefore best read as the demand for a **general logical account of factual sense**, not as a proposal to replace English.

The pressures. Four, and cumulative. Section 23's list of countless language-games defeats one general form. Section 28-31 show that ostension explains a word only where the place is already prepared, so naming cannot ground meaning. Colour exclusion - "this spot is red" against "this spot is green" - strains the independence of elementary propositions and was acknowledged in "Some Remarks on Logical Form" (1929), though it is a pressure rather than a refutation. Section 47 shows that "simple" has sense only relative to a game. **What "empirically" means.** ANALYSIS: Not that philosophy becomes an empirical science. Section 109 replaces explanation with **description**, and Section 122 sets the goal as a **perspicuous representation** that lets us see connections. The investigation is of grammar, conducted by comparison (Section 130-131).

The later account. Section 43 states the thesis with its own limitation. Section 66-67 remove the essence-demand through family resemblance and the spun thread. Section 19 and Section 23 place language-games within a **form of life**, and Section 241-242 locate agreement in judgments rather than opinions. Section 201 shows that no interpretation fixes its own application, and Section 258 turns the result on the inner domain the referential model seemed to fit best.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The transition is from a **theoretical** to a **therapeutic** conception of philosophy: Section 309's aim is to show the fly the way out of the fly-bottle. Its gain is release from the ideal-language model; its costs are the quietism Section 124 invites and an unresolved question about distinguishing correct use from innovation and error. CAUTION: Both books hold philosophy to be clarification, and both consume their own doctrine - the ladder at 6.54, the plural at Section 133.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus: anchor each stage to the quoted statement, and correct its one misleading implication early. A twenty-mark transition answer that does not say what the *Tractatus* really held about ordinary language has conceded a caricature.

Exam-length execution - 20 marks, about 330 to 400 words: thesis two lines; early four; pressures six; "empirically" three; later account five; verdict five.

- **Structure:** thesis -> what the early view held -> the pressures -> the sense of "empirically" -> the later account -> the verdict.
- **Doctrine:** depiction and logical form; use, games, forms of life, rules, private language.
- **Evidence:** 4.002, 5.5563, 6.54; Section 19, 23, 28-31, 43, 47, 66-67, 109, 122, 130-131, 201, 241-242, 258, 309, 124, 133; 1929 paper.
- **Distinction:** essence-demand against theory; description against empirical science.
- **Criticism:** quietism and the normativity of use, both named with their residues.

SUPPORTING ROUTED PARTS THAT BEAR ON THIS CLAUSE BUT ARE OWNED ELSEWHERE

ANALYSIS: The three parts below name Wittgenstein and are frequently mistaken for this clause's property. Each is owned by **Topic 06, Moore, Russell and Early Wittgenstein**. They are given here with a **contribution-and-boundary block** rather than a full model answer, because writing a full answer to them from this clause would be answering another syllabus item. ANALYSIS: Note that **2021**, the only year in which this clause owns nothing, nevertheless contains a Wittgenstein part - which is exactly why the boundary is worth knowing.

Supporting part A · 2018 · Q3(c) · 15 marks · owned by Topic 06, Moore, Russell and Early Wittgenstein

Question: How does Wittgenstein apply the distinction between 'saying' and 'showing' to point to a single way of apprehending the most decisive problems of philosophy? Is he justified? Give reasons for your answer.

- **What this clause may contribute:** one sentence noting that the later work abandons the saying/showing machinery along with the general propositional form it depended on, and replaces the single way of apprehending decisive problems with a **plurality** of grammatical methods (Section 133).
- **Boundary:** the doctrine of saying and showing, its relation to logical form, and its role in the *Tractatus*'s treatment of ethics, the mystical and the self are **Topic 06's** to expound.
- **WRONG:** **Do not** import meaning-as-use, language-games or the private-language argument into the body of that answer; they belong at most to a closing sentence on what became of the distinction.

Supporting part B · 2021 · Q4(c) · 15 marks · owned by Topic 06, Moore, Russell and Early Wittgenstein

Question: What does Wittgenstein mean by the statement - "Whereof one cannot speak, thereof one must be silent?" Critically discuss.

- **What this clause may contribute:** a closing contrast - the later Wittgenstein does not counsel silence about what cannot be said, but investigates the **grammar** of the words in which we were trying to say it, so that the injunction gives way to therapy (Section 109, 123, 309).
- **Boundary:** the ladder at 6.54, the limits of the sayable and the status of the *Tractatus*'s own propositions belong to **Topic 06**.
- **ANALYSIS: Why it matters here:** 2021 is the only year without a part owned by this clause, and this is that year's Wittgenstein part. Knowing where it belongs is itself a boundary mark.

Supporting part C · 2022 · Q3(c) · 15 marks · owned by Topic 06, Moore, Russell and Early Wittgenstein

Question: Is there any difference between pictorial form and logical form in Ludwig Wittgenstein's picture theory of language? How does the logical form define the relation between language and reality? Explain.

- **What this clause may contribute:** one sentence recording that the later work does not refine the notion of logical form but withdraws the demand it was introduced to satisfy, replacing determinacy-in-form with determinacy-in-**practice** (Section 201, Section 202).
- **Boundary:** the distinction between pictorial and logical form, and the account of representation it supports, are **Topic 06's** subject-matter.
- **WRONG:** **Do not** answer this part by asserting that the picture theory was refuted; the accurate later claim is that its governing assumption was diagnosed.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: "An ostensive definition can be variously interpreted in every case." Examine the significance of this remark for Wittgenstein's account of meaning.

Independent model answer

Thesis. The remark denies ostension the office it had been given - connecting language to the world from outside every practice - and removes the last refuge of the referential model of meaning.

The argument. Section 28 shows that pointing at two nuts while saying "This is called 'two'" leaves the lesson undetermined: the word might be taken for a number, a colour, a shape, a material or a proper name. Section 29-30 show that the obvious repair - "this *number* is called two" - borrows an understanding of "number", so that "*one has already to know (or be able to do) something in order to be capable of asking a thing's name*". The explanations do not terminate in a self-explaining item.

The positive condition. Section 31 supplies it through the chess-king: being shown the piece and told "This is the king" teaches its use only to someone who knows the shape of a game. The definition works "*when the place is already prepared*", and training (Section 5-6) and correction prepare it.

Significance. ANALYSIS: Meaning cannot be founded on naming, since naming presupposes the practice it was to ground; and a **private** ostensive definition, being ostension stripped of training, correction and prepared place, cannot fix a standard - which is why Section 258 is the heir of Section 28.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: Explain the distinction between a criterion and a symptom, and show why Wittgenstein needs it.

Independent model answer

Thesis. The distinction lets Wittgenstein make behaviour constitutive of the *concept* of pain without making pain identical with behaviour; without it, the private-language argument collapses into behaviourism.

The distinction. A **criterion (Kriterium)** is a grammatical ground, taught with the word and fixed by the language-game; a **symptom (Symptom)** is an inductive correlation discovered by experience. The *Blue Book* (dictated 1933-35, published 1958) gives the non-psychological case: we **defined** angina as the illness produced by a particular bacillus, so the bacillus is the criterion and the inflamed throat a symptom. For pain, the criterion is pain-behaviour **in appropriate circumstances**; a raised pulse or an actor's groan is a symptom.

Why it is needed. Without it the argument runs: sensation-words mean by public use, public use is behaviour, therefore "pain" means pain-behaviour - logical behaviourism, refuted by one successful pretence. With it: criteria are **defeasible**, so "he is in pain" is grounded but not entailed, and pretence is predicted rather than a counter-example.

The supporting remarks. Section 580 states that an "inner process" stands in need of outward criteria; Section 304 calls the sensation "*not a something, but not a nothing either*"; Section 307 concedes only a **grammatical** fiction; Section 244 makes the present-tense first-person utterance an **avowal**.

Qualification. ANALYSIS: Section 354 admits that the grammar **fluctuates** between criteria and symptoms, so the distinction is a grammatical role.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: "No course of action could be determined by a rule, because every course of action can be made out to accord with the rule." Critically examine Wittgenstein's treatment of this paradox.

Independent model answer

Thesis. The paradox is a **reductio** of the picture on which grasping a rule consists in attaching an interpretation to it; its conclusion is not that rules determine nothing but that rule-following is exhibited in trained practice.

How the paradox is generated. Section 185 imagines a pupil taught the "+2" series to 1000 who continues 1004, 1008, 1012 and protests that he went on "*in the same way*". Repeating the examples does not refute him; it comes natural to him to take the order as we should take "add 2 up to 1000, 4 up to 2000". Nothing already possessed - sign, examples, image, explanation - settles the matter, since each stands in the same need of application.

The diagnosis. Section 201's second part identifies the misunderstanding *"from the mere fact that in the course of our argument we give one interpretation after another; as if each one contented us at least for a moment, until we thought of yet another standing behind it."* Since **interpretation** is glossed as substituting one expression of the rule for another, the regress is structural, and the first step was the error.

The resolution. Section 201's third part asserts *"a way of grasping a rule which is not an interpretation, but which is exhibited in what we call 'obeying the rule' and 'going against it' in actual cases";* Section 202 adds that obeying a rule is a **practice**.

Two misreadings. ANALYSIS: Treating the paradox as a sceptical result ignores Section 201's own word "misunderstanding". ANALYSIS: Treating community behaviour as the criterion reinstates the collapse of "right" into "seems right", since a practice has **mistakes** where a regularity has exceptions.

Assessment. CAUTION: Kripke (1982) reads Section 201 as a sceptical paradox answered by assertion-conditions plus communal agreement, presenting it as the argument *as it struck him*; Baker, Hacker and McDowell read the text as dissolving rather than conceding. ANALYSIS: The ruling: philosophically valuable, since neither interpretation nor disposition fixes normativity; exegetically doubtful, since a sceptical *solution* is the constructive theory Section 128 and 133 disavow.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: "Philosophy leaves everything as it is." Does this commit Wittgenstein to quietism? Critically discuss.

Independent model answer

Thesis. The remark commits Wittgenstein to a severe restriction on what philosophy may attempt, but not to the political or critical quietism usually inferred from it - though the restriction is real and should be conceded rather than explained away.

The remark in context. Section 124 reads in full: philosophy *"may in no way interfere with the actual use of language; it can in the end only describe it. For it cannot give it any foundation either. It leaves everything as it is."* ANALYSIS: The first clause fixes the scope: what may not be interfered with is the **use of language**. Nothing is said about institutions, laws or social arrangements.

Why the restriction is imposed. Section 38 locates philosophical problems in language **idling** (*wenn die Sprache feiert*); Section 115 diagnoses captivity by a picture that *"lay in our language"*; Section 123 reclassifies the difficulty as *"I don't know my way about"*. If the trouble is disorientation rather than ignorance, then supplying a new theory would be supplying the wrong kind of thing - which is why Section 109 substitutes description for explanation and Section 128 holds that a philosophical thesis could never be debated.

Why it is not passivity. ANALYSIS: The method has identifiable operations: assembling **reminders** (Section 127), finding and inventing **intermediate cases** and producing a **perspicuous representation** that yields *"seeing connections"* (Section 122). Section 133 speaks of **methods**, in the plural, *"like different therapies"*, and locates success in being able to **stop** philosophising when one wants.

The objection at its strongest. ANALYSIS: A critic may grant all this and still observe that Wittgenstein forbids explanatory theory, foundational justification and revisionary legislation over grammar - most of what philosophy has attempted. That is a cost he accepts.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The charge of social conservatism fails, since Section 124's subject is grammar. The charge of disciplinary narrowing succeeds. CAUTION: The deeper difficulty is self-application: the claim that philosophical problems are grammatical confusions is itself general, and Section 133's plural mitigates without removing a problem inherited from the *Tractatus* ladder at 6.54.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: Does the account of language-games and forms of life commit Wittgenstein to relativism? Critically examine, with reference to the notion of agreement in judgments.

Independent model answer

Thesis. It does not, because agreement in judgments operates one level below truth-value, as the condition of determinate assertion rather than as its ground - but the account leaves a genuine gap, which is the absence of any theory of rational adjudication between practices.

The apparent commitment. Section 23 states that speaking a language is part of an activity or of a form of life, and that new games arise while others become obsolete; Section 19 that to imagine a language is to imagine a form of life; Section 217 that justification comes to an end and *"This is simply what I do."* Together these appear to make correctness internal to a practice and practices immune to external criticism.

Section 241's discrimination. The interlocutor puts the objection directly: *"So you are saying that human agreement decides what is true and what is false?"* The reply separates levels - *"It is what human beings say that is true and false; and they agree in the language they use. That is not agreement in opinions but in form of life."*

Section 242's argument. Communication requires agreement not only in definitions but, *"queer as this may sound"*, in **judgments**: if the results of measuring varied wildly from person to person, we should not have *inaccurate* measuring but **no** measuring at all. ANALYSIS: Removing shared judgments does not produce widespread error, which would presuppose a subject-matter; it removes the subject-matter. Disagreement is therefore evidence of a shared practice rather than of its absence.

Three further constraints. ANALYSIS: Forms of life include **natural history**: Section 25 and Section 415 place commanding, questioning and chatting alongside walking and eating, so the background is not wholly conventional. Section 217 marks the terminus of **justification**, not a criterion of correctness, and reading it as "whatever we do is right" reinstates at group level the collapse Section 258 exploits individually. The lion remark, in the material printed as *Philosophy of Psychology - A Fragment*, states a condition of intelligibility; Wittgenstein himself describes imagined alien practices, which presupposes that anthropological understanding is possible.

The genuine gap. ANALYSIS: What the text does not supply is any account of how one practice may rationally criticise another; and the sparse occurrence of "form of life" - Section 19, Section 23, Section 241 and PPF - means that elaborate constructions on it are interpretation rather than doctrine.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The relativism charge fails as stated; the honest residue is a silence about rational adjudication, which is a different and more interesting objection.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: What exactly does the private-language argument establish, and what does it leave standing? Critically discuss.

Independent model answer

Thesis. The argument establishes that private ostensive definition cannot found a language, and leaves standing the inner life, the solitary speaker, the felt character of sensation and the first-person asymmetry.

What is established. Section 243 fixes the target: words referring to *"what can only be known to the person speaking; to his immediate private sensations"*, so that another cannot understand the language even in principle. Section 258 tests it: the diarist's inward ostension can only mean that he will remember the connection rightly, *"and here we have no criterion of correctness ... whatever is going to seem right to me is right. And that only means that here we can't talk about 'right'."* Since Section 202 established that obeying a rule is a practice and that thinking one obeys is not obeying, no rule has been created - hence no meaning. Section 265 sharpens it: the internal check is like buying several copies of the same newspaper. Section 270 completes it: once a manometer supplies a public criterion the sign works, and the inner identification becomes irrelevant.

What the beetle adds. Section 293 shows that a private item which might differ in every box, change constantly, or be absent cannot fix the grammar of a **shared** sensation-word - a conclusion expressly conditional on the model of object and designation.

What is left standing. ANALYSIS: (i) Sensations: Section 304 - *"not a something, but not a nothing either!"* (ii) The solitary speaker: logical privacy is the target, and a man alone may use public-type criteria. (iii) The first/third-person asymmetry: Section 244 makes the present-tense first-person utterance an **avowal**, and Section 246 shows that *"I know I am in pain"* is sayable of me only as a joke. (iv) The inner life as a subject of description: Section 580 says the *concept* of an inner process needs outward criteria.

What is contested. CAUTION: The **memory objection**: public checks also use memory. The **community question**: actual community or in-principle shareable standards. The **phenomenological objection**: whether criterial grammar respects the felt character of experience.

Verdict. ANALYSIS: The argument is decisive against grounding meaning in the private inner, and is not a proof that mental states are behavioural, that solitude is impossible, or that sensations lack a felt quality. Reported at that strength it is durable; most circulating refutations refute a stronger claim.